Enterprise Architecture Strategic Context
Terms, Concepts, and Relationship Models

This document explains the key strategic and architectural concepts and terms that provide a disciplined way to structure an Enterprise Architecture engagement. They help ensure that architectural work remains anchored in business purpose and strategic necessity; that visible problems are connected to underlying issues; that strategy is translated into capability and operating changes; and that performance is continuously measured and fed back into governance and planning. Used together, these concepts create traceability from executive intent to practical execution.

The Overall Strategic Context Model

The overall model links the major concepts into a coherent chain. Vision and Mission establish purposes. Business Drivers explain why change is necessary. Goals and Objectives define what success looks like. Strategies identify the chosen approaches. Capability Model and Operating Model translate strategic intent into business and architectural design. Metrics provide evidence of performance. The Requirements Register captures the concrete implications for execution.

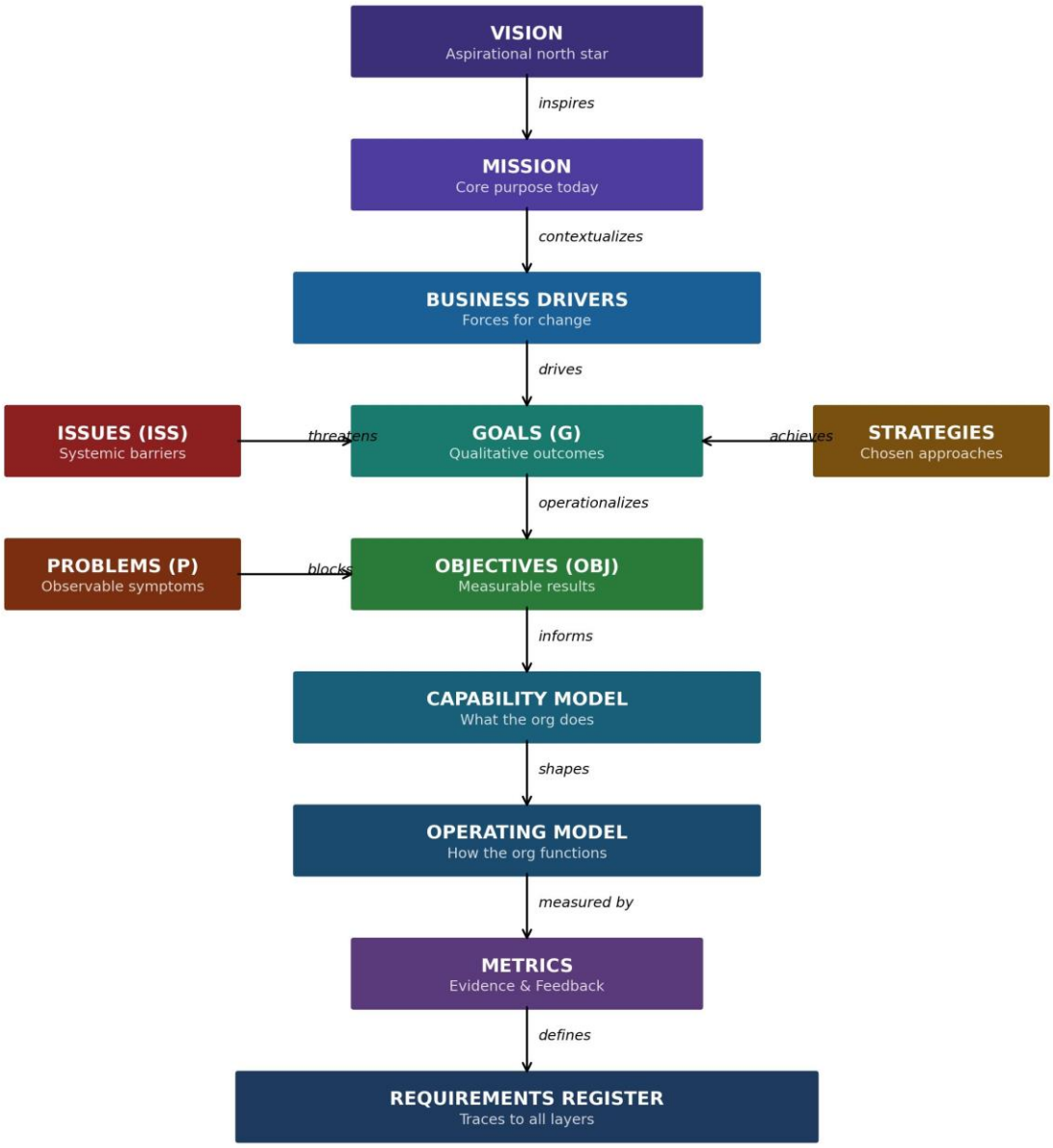
VISION
Aspirational north star
inspires
MISSION
Core purpose today
contextualizes
BUSINESS DRIVERS
Forces for change
drives
ISSUES (ISS)
Systemic barriers
threatens
GOALS (G)
Qualitative outcomes
achieves
STRATEGIES
Chosen approaches
operationalizes
PROBLEMS (P)
Observable symptoms
blocks
OBJECTIVES (OBJ)
Measurable results
informs
CAPABILITY MODEL
What the org does
shapes
OPERATING MODEL
How the org functions
measured by
METRICS
Evidence & Feedback
defines
REQUIREMENTS REGISTER
Traces to all layers

Figure 1. Overall Enterprise Architecture strategic context model.

The key relationships can be summarized as follows:

- Vision inspires Mission.
- Mission contextualizes Business Drivers.
- Business Drivers drive Goals.
- Goals are operationalized through Objectives.
- Strategies are chosen to achieve Goals.
- Issues threaten Goals.
- Problems block Objectives.
- Objectives and Strategies inform the Capability Model.
- Capability Model shapes the Operating Model.
- Operating Model performance is measured through Metrics.
- Metrics validate success or surface new Issues and Problems.
- The Requirements Register captures the implications of all of the above for execution.

1. Core Strategic Terms

- **Vision —** A forward-looking, aspiration description of what the organization intends to become or achieve in the long term. It provides the north star for strategic direction.
- **Mission —** A concise statement of the organization's core purpose, the value it delivers, and why it exists today.
- **Business Drivers —** Internal or external forces that make the engagement necessary. These may be opportunities, threats, mandates, market shifts, policy changes, or performance pressures.
- **Goals —** Qualitative desired outcomes that respond to business drivers. Goals express what success looks like in broad terms.
- **Objectives —** Specific, measurable, and time-bound results that operationalize goals. Objectives make goals testable and manageable.
- **Strategies —** Chosen approaches for achieving goals. Strategies describe the broad course of action the enterprise will follow.

2. Barrier and Risk Terms

- **Issues —** Systemic barriers that threaten goals. Issues are structural and persistent. They are not merely visible symptoms; rather, they are underlying conditions such as fragmented governance, siloed information, or weak accountability.
- **Problems —** Specific, observable symptoms that block objectives. Problems are concrete manifestations that can usually be seen directly, such as duplicate records, reporting delays, or manual rework.

A useful distinction is that **issues are usually root-cause of conditions**, while problems are the visible signs that those conditions are affecting execution. In practice, issues often cause recurring problems.

3. Architectural and Execution Terms

- **Capability Model —** A stable, hierarchical map of what the organization does to achieve business outcomes, independent of organizational structure or current systems. Capabilities combine people, processes, information, and tools.
- **Operating Model —** A high-level representation of how the organization functions in order to deliver value. It describes how process, information, technology, and governance are organized and coordinated.
- **Requirements Register —** A structured record of requirements that trace back to the strategic context. It links requirements to drivers, goals, objectives, issues, problems, capabilities, operating model elements, and metrics.

4. Measurement and Evidence Terms

- **Metrics —** Specific, quantifiable measures used to track progress, performance, and outcomes. Metrics provide evidence as to whether strategies are working and whether objectives and goals are being achieved.

Metrics can be leading or lagging. Leading metrics indicate whether future performance is likely to improve or worsen. Lagging metrics indicate whether desired outcomes have already been achieved.

6. Issues, Problems, and Threats to Execution

Issues and Problems must be treated differently. Issues are systemic barriers that threaten the achievement of goals. Problems are specific, observable symptoms that block the achievement of objectives. This distinction is important because addressing only problems may relieve symptoms temporarily, while leaving the underlying issue unresolved.

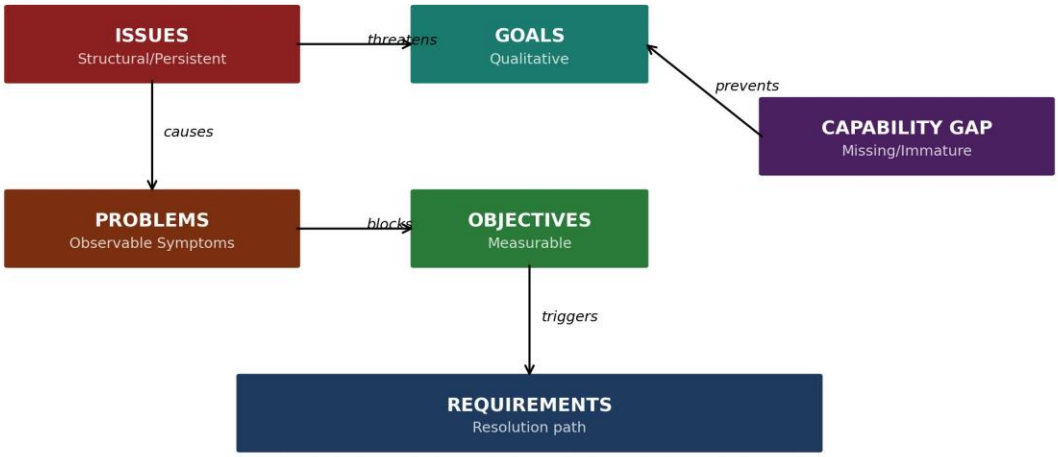

Figure 2. Threat and barrier model showing how issues and problems affect goals and objectives.

7. From Strategy to Architecture and Execution

Strategies alone do not create change. They must be translated into the capabilities the organization needs, and then into the operating model that determines how work, information, technology, and governance will function in practice. The Capability Model defines what the enterprise must be able to do. The Operating Model defines how those capabilities are organized and delivered.

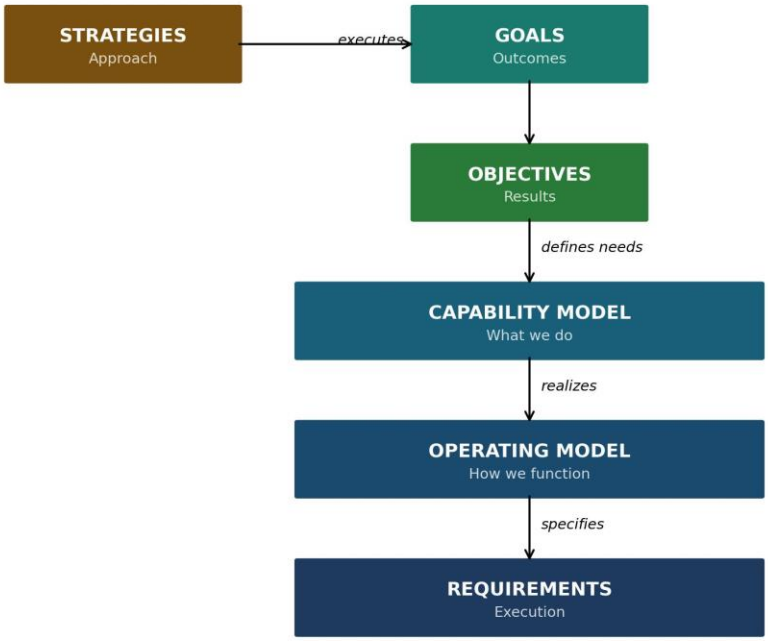

Figure 3. Strategy-to-execution bridge through capability and operating models.

8. Metrics and Feedback Loops

Metrics close the loop between intention and evidence. If performance is on target, metrics validate the strategy and indicate that objectives and goals are being achieved. If performance falls outside acceptable thresholds, metrics help surface new problems or reveal deeper systemic issues. In this way, metrics provide the evidence base for architectural governance and continuous improvement.

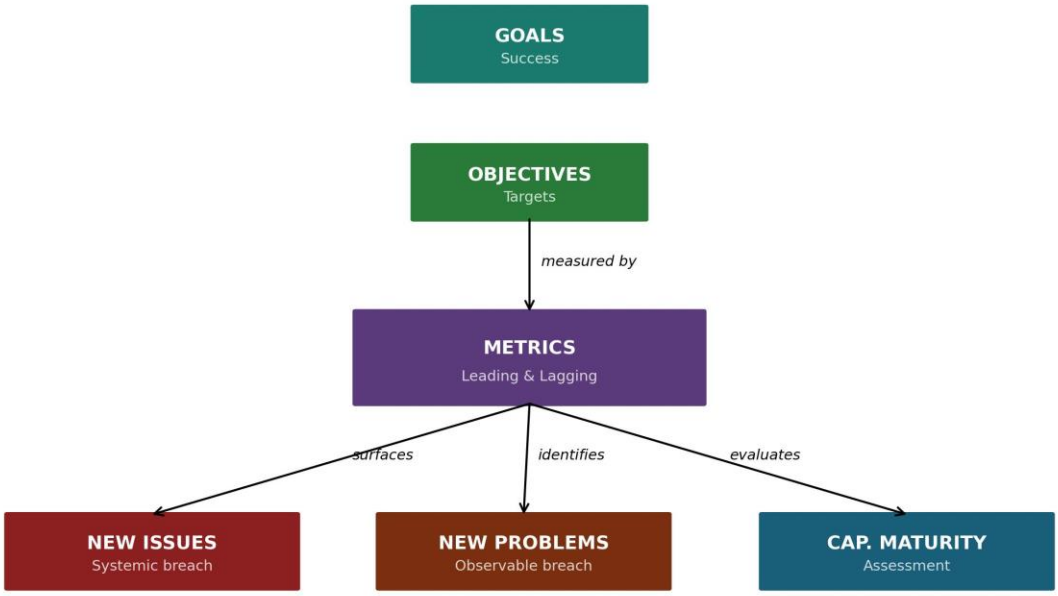

Figure 4. Metrics feedback loop and its role in surfacing new issues and problems.